Question: Do you not confuse the social philosophy and the religious philosophy of India—for example, do not the Dharmaśāstras essentially ignore the spiritual goal of man, whereas you relate it intimately to social philosophy?

Answer: Such terms as *"mokṣa," "mukti,"* and *"niḥśreyas-siddhi"* (the attainment of the highest) are to be found in almost all basic texts. And, although it would be correct to say that the social goals in India had nothing to do with the individual's spiritual goal, almost all individuals in India are conscious of the idea of their own *mokṣa,* at least in the later stages of lives. The religious goal of life had a primacy even in the secular spheres of life. The separation of life into autonomous compartments of the political, legal, economic, and social spheres is a purely contemporary phenomenon in India.

Question: Your justification of duties as prior to the rights of the individual seem to be open to question. Would you elaborate a bit?

Answer: The point is simple enough. A society in which all individuals are conscious only of their individual rights and do their duties exclusively for fear of losing their rights would not be a strictly ethical society, nor would the behavior of the individual be strictly ethical. We can still imagine a society wherein all individuals are prompted and motivated in action solely by regard for their ethical duties in all circumstances. The Indians thus based their social structure on duties and obligations rather than on rights. The social end in both cases may be the same, but the difference lies in the Indian emphasis on the ethical motivation.

NOTES

1. What has been said here pertains primarily to Hindu society. The Buddhist in India, from the time of the Buddha himself, protested against all kind of class or birth distinction and gave full dignity and status to all individuals, but, later, Buddhism almost disappeared from the country of its origin. When the Muslims came to India in about the twelfth century A.D. though they adopted in practice the Hindu social evils of caste hierarchies in daily life, they were by their religion not supposed to have any social distinction between man and man. Thus, what pertains socially to Hindu society is true of the entire Indian social structure, in thought and practice.
2. J.L. Davies, *A Short History of Women* (New York: Viking Press, 1927), p. 172. Quoted in A. S. Altekar, *The Position of Women in Hindu Society* (Benares: The Cultural Publishing House, 1938), p. 407.